May 2026, with a clear attempt to enter the Bhadralok imagination—the educated, culturally influential class that shapes opinion and voting patterns across Kolkata, Howrah, North and South 24 Parganas, Nadia, Hooghly, Burdwan and parts of Birbhum. Analysts estimate that their influence extends across 80-100 of Bengal's 294 assembly segments, translating into sway over 15-18 of the state's 42 Lok Sabha seats.

BJP'S BENGAL REALITY

The BJP's Bengal project, insiders admit, is layered and long-term. The party failed to unseat chief minister Mamata Banerjee in 2021, stopping at 77 assembly seats, with a 38.15 per cent vote share, while the Trinamool Congress (TMC) swept 214, with 48.02 per cent. Its high-water mark was the 2019 Lok Sabha election, when it secured 18 seats and 40.64 per cent vote share. However, this tally dipped to 12 in 2024, and the vote share to 39.08 per cent.

The party's struggle is the sharpest in Muslim-majority districts such as Murshidabad, Malda and Uttar Dinajpur—each with over 50 per cent Muslim population. In another seven districts—South and North 24 Parganas, Nadia, Cooch Behar, Dakshin Dinajpur, Howrah and Birbhum—the Muslim population ranges between 20 and 30 per cent. Together, these 10 districts account for 166 assembly seats, of which the TMC won 130 in 2021. Despite attempts at reverse polarisation, Muslim votes remained consolidated behind the TMC in recent elections. Against this backdrop, invoking Bengal's icons—Bankim, Rabindranath Tagore, Subhas Chandra Bose—now forms the core of the BJP's cultural strategy.

Bankim wrote *Vande Mataram* in 1875 and published it in his novel *Anandamath* in 1882 amid a rising nationalist ferment. Its verses—*'Sujalam suphalam malayaja sheetalam'* (rich with water, bountiful with fruits, cooled by the mountain breeze)—celebrated the motherland as divine. During the 1905 movement against the partition of Bengal, it became the anthem of resistance. By the 1930s, however, its invocation of goddess Durga triggered objections from sections of Muslim leaders. The Muslim League called it exclusionary. In 1937, the Congress, led by Nehru, and supported by Mahatma Gandhi, restricted official usage to the first two stanzas. Gandhi defended this in *Harijan*: "It is a beautiful song, but not all its verses may appeal to every Indian. Unity demands restraint." For Modi, that restraint was "betrayal". "Those who cut *Vande Mataram*, cut the spirit of Bharat," he declared in Parliament. This framing dovetails with the BJP's long-standing critique of "appeasement politics".

Modi's message was national as well. In the Hindi belt, *Vande Mataram* resonates as shorthand for cultural unity and civilisational pride. In Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, where BJP's internal data shows issues of 'national pride' outperform economic concerns by over 20 percentage points in voter engagement, Bankim's imagery reinforces the party's ideological pitch. In Assam, where *Anandamath* is partly set, the party has sought to blend Bankim's legacy with Assamese identity. For the BJP, these sentiments form the bedrock of its narrative of a Viksit Bharat by 2047. *Vande Mataram* provides the soundtrack. The debate is also part of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's broader project of 'decolonising the mind'—an effort to foreground aspects of nationalism it believes Marxist historians underplayed, or ignored.

THE NEW BATTLEGROUND

As the BJP pushes its cultural line, the Opposition responds with inclusion and charges of distraction

- **Modi framed the 1937 Congress decision to limit the song's stanzas as historic weakness**
- **The messaging targeted Bengal's Bhadralok to shift cultural and electoral currents before 2026 assembly polls**
- **The Congress called the 1937 decision not as weakness but as inclusive nation-building, arguing that Gandhi and Nehru acted to preserve unity**
- **The Opposition accused Modi of using the debate for the 2026 Bengal polls, diverting attention from economic distress and farmers' issues**

THE OPPOSITION PUSHBACK

The Congress has tried to counter the narrative, arguing that Gandhi and Nehru's compromise was an act of inclusion, not surrender. Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, the party's MP from Wayanad, said: "We are here for two reasons. One, Bengal elections are coming up, so the prime minister wants to play his role." The second, she said, was an old aim of "theirs"; it was, she said, "to hurl new allegations at those who gave their lives for Independence. To divert attention from the real issues." On December 9, party president and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Mallikarjun Kharge, added: "While the government sings songs, farmers cannot sell their crops."

In the Lok Sabha, Samajwadi Party chief and Kannauj MP Akhilesh Yadav retorted, "Today, divisive elements are using *Vande Mataram* to create divisions." National Conference MP from Srinagar, Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi, argued: "We fought for this nation's freedom from outsiders; if needed, we will fight tooth and nail for our freedom within this nation against anyone who denies us our constitutional rights." TMC MPs attempted cultural resistance. "You cannot nationalise Bengal's soul," said Mahua Moitra. For the BJP, that is precisely the point—to dissolve Bengal's regional exceptionalism into a broader nationalist story.

As a senior BJP strategist puts it: "Development unites through hope. Culture unites through identity. We need both." For the Opposition, the challenge remains familiar: how to counter cultural nationalism without appearing to reject culture itself. ■